
CAREER COMPASS

CLARITY TODAY. CONFIDENCE TOMORROW.
A FUTURE ON YOUR TERMS.



NAVIGATE WITH PURPOSE. LEAD WITH IMPACT.

NESRIN ABD ELHAKIM

*For everyone who ever sat at their desk
wondering,
"Is this really it?"*

It is not.

Your best chapter has not been written yet.
Let's write it together.

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INTRODUCTION

Why You Are Here — And Why That Matters

The story that started this book

SUCCESS STORY — LAYLA'S TURNING POINT

Layla was 32, a marketing manager at a company she had worked for since graduating. On paper, everything looked fine. Decent salary. Good title. Stable employer. But every Sunday evening, a familiar dread would settle in her chest. She had spent six years climbing a ladder she was not sure she had chosen. One afternoon, during a call that she had already forgotten five minutes later, she typed into her notes app: 'What am I actually doing?' Three months later, after working through a career coaching process, she had resigned, completed a digital strategy certification, and was three weeks into a new role that genuinely excited her. She told me: 'I wasn't lost. I just hadn't given myself permission to find a new direction.'

You picked up this book for a reason. Maybe you are at the beginning of your career, staring at an overwhelming number of choices and unsure how to choose. Maybe you are ten years in and wondering how you ended up here. Maybe you are exhausted by the performance of a career that looks successful from the outside but feels hollow from the inside.

Whatever your reason, welcome. You are in the right place.

"You are not behind. You are not stuck. You are standing at a crossroads — and that is exactly where growth begins."

The Career Confusion Crisis

We live in an era of career overwhelm. More options than ever. More pressure than ever. More visibility into other people's choices than at any point in human history. The infinite scroll of LinkedIn — with its promotions, job announcements, and carefully curated professional wins — creates a constant ambient pressure: *everyone else seems to have figured it out. Why haven't I?*

Here is the truth that social media does not show you: the person who just posted about their "dream job" negotiated for six months to get it. The founder celebrating their company milestone had three failed businesses before this one. The executive with the impressive title has an inbox full of problems and a calendar full of meetings they would rather skip.

The Fear of the Wrong Decision

One of the most paralyzing forces in career development is the fear of making the wrong move. What if I change direction and regret it? What if I invest in this qualification and it doesn't pay off? What if I ask for the promotion and get turned down? This fear creates the most common career mistake of all: **staying still**.

CAREER COACH TIP

Your career is not a chess match where one wrong move ends the game. It is a long, winding, frequently surprising journey. The people who navigate it best are not the ones who make the fewest mistakes — they are the ones who move anyway and learn as they go.

How This Book Works

Career Compass is structured as a complete career navigation system — from discovering who you are to designing the future you want. Each chapter includes frameworks, real-world examples, coaching exercises, reflection questions, and practical tools you can use immediately.

Read it cover to cover for a complete transformation. Or navigate directly to the chapters that address your most pressing career challenges right now. Either way, this book meets you exactly where you are.

ACTION STEP

Before you turn to Chapter 1, take two minutes and write down the single most important career question you are trying to answer right now. Keep that question in mind as you read.

PART ONE

Find Your Direction

Before you can navigate toward a destination, you need to know where you are — and who you really are.

CHAPTER 1

Who Am I Beyond My Job Title?

Discovering your strengths, values, and what actually drives you

In most professional introductions, we say what we do for a living. "I'm a marketing manager." "I'm an engineer." "I'm in HR." Our job title becomes a shorthand for our entire professional identity — and often bleeds into our personal one. But here is the problem with that: job titles change. Companies downsize. Industries transform. If your entire sense of professional self is built on a title, you are one redundancy away from an identity crisis.

The most resilient, fulfilled, and consistently successful professionals I have coached share one thing in common: they knew exactly who they were beyond what they did. This chapter helps you find that.

SUCCESS STORY — THE ENGINEER WHO FOUND HIS VOICE

Daniel spent twelve years as a civil engineer, respected by his team but quietly restless. He had always been the person colleagues came to when they were stuck — not for technical advice, but for clarity, perspective, and the kind of calm that defused difficult situations. Through a career coaching conversation, Daniel realised his greatest strength was not engineering. It was helping complex groups of people reach agreement. He retrained as an organisational development consultant and has never looked back. 'I was using 20% of my abilities in my old role,' he told me. 'Now I use all of them.'

Your Strengths: What You Do Best

Strengths are not just the things you are good at — they are the things you are good at *and* that energise you when you do them. A strength that drains you is a skill, not a strength. This distinction matters profoundly for career decisions.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- ◆ What tasks do I complete that make time disappear?
- ◆ What do colleagues consistently ask for my help with?
- ◆ What comes so naturally to me that I assume everyone can do it?
- ◆ When have I felt most confident and capable in a professional setting?
- ◆ What would I do at work even if it was not in my job description?

CAREER COACH TIP

The 'I wish I had more time for...' test: finish this sentence honestly. The answer almost always points directly toward a genuine strength you are underusing.

Your Values: What You Stand For

Career dissatisfaction is very often a values misalignment problem. When the work you do conflicts with what you fundamentally believe is important, no amount of salary, title, or perks will make it feel right. Values are the bedrock. Get them wrong, and the whole career sits unstably on top.

Common professional values include: autonomy, creativity, security, impact, recognition, learning, service, leadership, excellence, belonging, adventure, and purpose. **There are no wrong values** — only values that are or are not well-matched to the environment you are working in.

VALUES IDENTIFICATION EXERCISE

- ☐ Circle your top 10 values from the list above (or add your own).

- ☐ Narrow to your top 5 by asking: which would I be least willing to compromise?

- ☐ For each of your top 5, give a real workplace example where it was honoured or violated.

- ☐ Look at your current role: how many of your top 5 are genuinely present?

- ☐ Where you find misalignment, note it — this is career-critical information.

Your Natural Talents and Passions

Talents are the things your brain does effortlessly — patterns you spot before others do, connections you make naturally, the way you see problems as puzzles to be solved rather than burdens to be endured. Passions are the topics, activities, and questions that make you lean forward. They are often undervalued in careers because we are taught that work is supposed to be serious, not enjoyable.

JOURNAL PROMPTS

- ◆ *If I could spend one full day doing anything professional — with no financial pressure — what would it be?*
- ◆ *What topics could I talk about for hours without losing energy?*
- ◆ *What kind of work have I done that gave me genuine satisfaction, regardless of whether I was paid for it?*
- ◆ *What are three things I am genuinely curious about right now?*

ACTION STEP

Complete the full Self-Discovery Worksheet in the Bonus Section before moving to Chapter 2. It consolidates your strengths, values, talents, and motivators into a single clear picture.

CHAPTER 2

Defining Success on Your Own Terms

Why society's definition of success may not be yours — and that is perfectly fine

Ask ten people to define career success and you will get ten different answers. Or will you? In most professional cultures, success has been quietly standardised: higher title, higher salary, bigger company, more responsibility, more visibility. This definition is so pervasive that many people pursue it on autopilot — and only discover it does not fit when they finally achieve it.

"The saddest professional moment is reaching the top of a ladder you never actually wanted to climb."

The Achievement Trap

Achievement is seductive. Each new accomplishment signals safety, competence, and worth — which is why high achievers so often keep achieving long past the point where it is making them happy. The achievement trap is the pattern of reaching a goal, briefly celebrating it, then immediately reaching for the next one, without ever pausing to ask: *is this what I actually want?*

SUCCESS STORY — THE VP WHO WANTED TO TEACH

Priya had just been promoted to Vice President at 38. It was the role she had worked toward for a decade. Three weeks in, she called me in crisis. 'I've been working towards this for so long,' she said, 'but I feel nothing. Actually, I feel worse.' Through our coaching work, Priya realised that what she had always

loved most was developing junior talent — mentoring, teaching, helping people grow. The VP role gave her fewer opportunities to do this, not more. She eventually created a hybrid role that combined her seniority with a formal mentoring programme she designed. 'I finally feel like I'm doing the right job,' she said.

Happiness vs Achievement: The Tension That Defines Careers

Psychologists distinguish between two types of well-being: *hedonic* (pleasure, positive emotion, enjoyment) and *eudaimonic* (meaning, purpose, contribution). Careers that prioritise only achievement often generate the first and sacrifice the second. The most fulfilled professionals I know have found work that activates both.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- ◆ If I removed salary and status from the equation, what would my ideal working life look like?
- ◆ Who in my professional life do I genuinely admire — and what is it about their career that draws me?
- ◆ What would I regret not having done or tried if I looked back at 70?
- ◆ When was the last time I felt genuinely proud — not just successful — at work?

Writing Your Personal Success Definition

Your personal definition of success should include four components: what you want to **do** (activities), what you want to **have** (outcomes), who you want to **become** (identity), and the **impact** you want to make. Take time to write all four — and revisit them annually, because success evolves as you do.

JOURNAL PROMPTS

- ◆ *My ideal working day from morning to evening looks like...*
- ◆ *In five years, I want to be known for...*
- ◆ *The non-negotiables in my career — things I will not compromise — are...*
- ◆ *The version of professional success I was raised to believe in vs the one I actually want is...*

CHAPTER 3

Creating Your Career Vision

Mapping where you want to go — clearly, specifically, and compellingly

A career without a vision is a career driven entirely by circumstance — by whoever calls, whatever job is advertised, whichever direction your current employer points you. A career with a vision is fundamentally different. It does not remove uncertainty or eliminate setbacks. But it gives you a compass that tells you whether each step is taking you toward what you actually want — or away from it.

The One-Year Career Vision

Your one-year vision should be ambitious enough to motivate you and specific enough to be measurable. Vague visions produce vague results. "I want to do better" is not a vision. "I want to be promoted to Senior Manager at my current company, having led my first significant cross-functional project and built relationships with three senior leaders" is a vision.

ONE-YEAR CAREER VISION BUILDER

- ☐ My role/title in 12 months: _____
- ☐ My salary/compensation target: _____
- ☐ The key skill I will have mastered: _____
- ☐ The most significant achievement I will have delivered: _____
- ☐ The relationship I will have built: _____

□ How I will feel about my work: _____

The Three-Year Career Vision

Three years is the sweet spot for meaningful career transformation. It is long enough to make significant moves — retraining, building expertise, pivoting sectors — but short enough to feel real and urgent. Your three-year vision should describe not just what you will be doing, but who you will have become.

The Five-Year Career Vision

Five years out, you are thinking about legacy, impact, and identity. Where are you in the hierarchy of your field? What are you known for? What have you built? Who have you helped? The further out you project, the more the vision should speak to purpose rather than just position.

Your Personal Mission Statement

A personal mission statement is a single, powerful sentence that captures what you do, why you do it, and who you serve. It is the North Star of your career compass. Examples: "I help organisations find and develop talent that changes their trajectory." "I create technology that makes healthcare more accessible for underserved communities." "I build and lead teams that do work they are genuinely proud of."

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- ◆ If I could be remembered professionally for just one thing, what would it be?
- ◆ Whose career — real or fictional — do I most admire, and what about it resonates with me?
- ◆ What problem in the world do I feel genuinely called to help solve?

ACTION STEP

Write your personal mission statement today. It does not need to be perfect — it will evolve. Write it in pencil. The act of committing it to paper changes how you make every subsequent career decision.

PART TWO

Build Your Foundation

*The skills, brand, and network that make your
career resilient and remarkable.*

CHAPTER 4

The Skills That Will Future-Proof Your Career

What to build now so your career thrives in a world that keeps changing

The half-life of professional skills is shrinking. A technical skill that made someone invaluable in 2018 may be automated or obsolete by 2026. The professionals who will thrive in the next decade are not the ones with the most specialised knowledge — they are the ones who have built the durable, human capabilities that technology cannot replace.

The Eight Career-Critical Skills

1. Communication. The ability to communicate clearly, persuasively, and with emotional intelligence — in writing, in conversation, and in presentation — is the most universally valued professional skill that exists. Every other capability is amplified by strong communication and limited by weak communication.

2. Emotional Intelligence. Self-awareness, empathy, and the ability to read and manage interpersonal dynamics separate professionals who advance from those who plateau. EQ is especially critical in leadership — and it is learnable.

3. Critical Thinking. The ability to evaluate information, identify assumptions, and arrive at well-reasoned conclusions is increasingly rare and increasingly valuable as information overload intensifies.

4. Problem Solving. Not just identifying problems — which many people can do — but generating, evaluating, and implementing practical solutions. Problem-solving skill is what transforms a thoughtful employee into an indispensable one.

5. Adaptability. The capacity to embrace change, learn new tools, and thrive under ambiguity is perhaps the defining career skill of the current decade. Rigid professionals get left behind. Adaptable ones get promoted.

6. Leadership. Leadership is not a title — it is a behaviour. Taking initiative, inspiring others, making decisions under uncertainty, and owning outcomes regardless of formal authority are behaviours available to every professional at every level.

7. Digital Literacy. You do not need to code to be digitally literate. But you do need to be comfortable with data, digital tools, and the logic of how technology works — well enough to collaborate with technical teams and evaluate digital solutions confidently.

8. AI Readiness. Artificial Intelligence is not coming — it is here. The professionals who will thrive are not those who fear AI but those who learn to work alongside it: using AI tools to enhance their output, while developing the uniquely human capabilities (judgment, empathy, creativity, ethics) that AI cannot replicate.

YOUR SKILLS DEVELOPMENT PLAN

- ☐ Identify your 2 strongest skills from the list above — how can you deepen them?

- ☐ Identify your 2 weakest skills — what is one concrete step to improve each?

- ☐ Find one online course, book, or mentor for your priority development area this quarter.

- ☐ Schedule 30 minutes per week for deliberate skill-building — non-negotiable.

- ☐ Identify someone in your network who excels at your target skill and ask for insight.

△ COMMON MISTAKE

Assuming that formal qualifications alone future-proof your career. Credentials open doors — skills keep you in the room. Invest in both, but never confuse having a certificate with having the capability.

CHAPTER 5

Personal Branding in the Digital Age

Your professional reputation exists online whether you manage it or not

Here is a fact that still surprises many professionals: the moment your name appears in a recruiter's search, you are being assessed. Your LinkedIn profile, your digital footprint, your published content, and your online presence are all part of an impression formed before you exchange a single word. Personal branding is not vanity. It is professional infrastructure.

"Your personal brand is what people say about you when you are not in the room — and increasingly, what they find when they search for you."

The LinkedIn Formula

LinkedIn is the single most important professional platform available, and most people use approximately 20% of its potential. Here is what actually moves the needle:

Your Headline: This is not your job title. It is your professional value proposition. Instead of "HR Manager at XYZ Corp" — try "HR Leader | Talent Strategy | Culture Architect | Helping Organisations Build Teams They're Proud Of." Keywords plus value plus personality.

Your About Section: First person. Conversational. Story-led. It should answer three questions: who are you professionally, what can you do for the person reading this, and what do you stand for? End with a call to action.

Your Experience: Achievement-led, not duty-led. Three to five bullet points per role, each beginning with a strong action verb and including a measurable outcome wherever possible.

LINKEDIN PROFILE OPTIMISATION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Professional headshot — clear, recent, bright background, genuine smile
- ☐ Headline with keywords, value proposition, and personality
- ☐ Custom banner image that reflects your professional brand
- ☐ About section written in first person with a clear narrative and call to action
- ☐ Every role has 3-5 achievement-based bullet points
- ☐ Skills section has your 10 most relevant competencies listed
- ☐ At least 3 recommendations from managers, clients, or colleagues
- ☐ Featured section showcases your best work, content, or credentials
- ☐ Activity section shows regular, value-adding engagement
- ☐ Open to Work or actively posting — not a dormant profile

Building Thought Leadership

Thought leadership does not require you to have revolutionary ideas. It requires you to share genuine perspectives on your area of expertise — consistently, authentically, and with the reader in mind. One post per week that adds real value to your professional community will compound significantly over twelve months.

CAREER COACH TIP

The easiest thought leadership content format: share a lesson you learned this week, a challenge you navigated, or an observation from your work. Professionals crave authenticity, not perfection.

△ **COMMON MISTAKE**

Sending connection requests without a personalised message. You are not a LinkedIn vacuum cleaner. Be selective, be personal, and be genuine. Quality connections compound. Quantity connections just add noise.

CHAPTER 6

Networking With Confidence

Building authentic professional relationships that open doors — without feeling fake

The word "networking" makes many professionals cringe. It conjures images of awkward conference cocktail hours, forced conversations, and the uncomfortable feeling of treating people as a means to an end. This version of networking is indeed unpleasant — and largely ineffective. The good news is that it is not the only version available to you.

Effective professional networking is simply the art of building genuine relationships with people whose work interests you, whom you respect, and with whom you share professional common ground. When it is done authentically, it does not feel like networking at all. It feels like having good conversations.

Networking for Introverts

If you are an introvert — and many of the most impressive professionals I know are — traditional networking environments may feel genuinely exhausting. The answer is not to force yourself to perform extroversion. It is to find the networking formats that suit your strengths: one-on-one conversations rather than large group events, written communication rather than cold approaches, online communities rather than physical events.

SUCCESS STORY — THE INTROVERT WHO BUILT A NETWORK OF 50

Amara, a financial analyst and self-described introvert, grew her professional network from 12 to over 50 high-quality connections in one year without attending a single networking event. Her approach: she spent 20 minutes every Friday leaving thoughtful comments on LinkedIn posts in her field, followed by a connection request referencing the comment. Her response rate was above 70%.

'I stopped thinking about networking as something I had to do,' she told me. 'I started thinking about it as connecting with people who were interesting. The network followed naturally.'

Finding Mentors

A mentor can compress years of professional development into months. But most professionals never actively seek one because they are not sure how to ask or what to offer in return. The answer to both is simpler than you think: be specific about what you are looking for, be respectful of their time, and bring genuine curiosity to every conversation.

NETWORKING CONVERSATION STARTER SCRIPTS

- ❑ Connection request: 'Hi [Name], I've been following your work on [topic] with real interest. I'm building expertise in [area] and would love to connect and learn from your perspective.'
- ❑ Reaching out for a conversation: 'I've been inspired by your career journey, particularly [specific thing]. I'm navigating a similar decision right now — would you have 20 minutes for a brief call?'
- ❑ Post-event follow-up: 'Hi [Name], it was great to meet you at [event]. Your point about [specific topic] stuck with me. I'd love to continue that conversation.'
- ❑ Asking for a mentor: 'I deeply respect the way you [specific quality]. I'm at a point in my career where your perspective would be invaluable. Would you be open to a mentoring conversation once per quarter?'

ACTION STEP

This week, identify three people you admire professionally. Send one personalised connection request to each, referencing something specific about their work. Focus on giving value in the connection, not asking for anything.

PART THREE

Create Opportunities

The CV, the search strategy, and the interview skills that get you in the room — and get you the offer.

CHAPTER 7

Mastering the Job Search

Finding the opportunities that others miss

The conventional job search — find a posting, apply, wait, repeat — is the least effective way to find a great role. It is the most visible approach, which makes it the most crowded. The most successful job seekers I have worked with found their positions through a combination of strategic networking, proactive outreach, and inside knowledge — not by being the 200th application in a pile.

The Hidden Job Market

Research consistently suggests that a significant proportion of professional roles are filled before they are ever publicly advertised — through internal movement, referrals, and direct outreach. The professionals who access this market consistently are the ones who have invested in their network, built a visible professional brand, and are known to decision-makers in their field before a vacancy ever exists.

CAREER COACH TIP

The best time to network for your next job is before you need a job. Build and maintain your professional relationships continuously — not frantically when you are already job-searching.

Strategic Applications

Quality over quantity is not just a cliché in job searching — it is a survival strategy. A tailored application that demonstrates genuine knowledge of the company, specific alignment with the role, and a compelling personal value proposition will outperform

fifty generic applications every time. For every application you send, spend at least 20 minutes on company research and 15 minutes tailoring your CV and cover letter.

A Recruiter's Inside View

Having sat on both sides of the recruitment process, here is what I can tell you honestly about how recruiters work: we are time-pressured, pattern-matching humans who want nothing more than to find the right person quickly. We are not trying to reject you — we are trying to find a reason to advance you. Make that easy for us.

YOUR 30-DAY JOB SEARCH ACTION PLAN

- ☐ Week 1: Update CV, LinkedIn profile, and define your target role and companies clearly.
- ☐ Week 2: Research 20 target companies. Find the relevant hiring manager or HR contact at each.
- ☐ Week 3: Reach out to 5 people in your network who might have inside knowledge of target companies.
- ☐ Week 4: Send 5 highly tailored applications to your top 5 priority roles.
- ☐ Daily: Spend 20 minutes on LinkedIn — engaging, connecting, and monitoring opportunities.
- ☐ Weekly: Follow up on all pending applications politely and professionally.

△ COMMON MISTAKE

Applying to every job that vaguely matches your skills. Recruiters can instantly recognise a scatter-gun application. Targeted, tailored, and thoughtful applications will always outperform volume.

CHAPTER 8

Writing a Winning CV

The document that opens the door — if it's built right

Your CV is not a record of your employment history. It is a marketing document. Its sole purpose is to make a recruiter want to have a conversation with you. Every word, every bullet point, every formatting decision should serve that purpose — or it should not be there.

The Modern CV Formula

Length: One page for under 7 years of experience. Two pages maximum for senior professionals. No exceptions.

Format: Clean, uncluttered, ATS-friendly. No tables, no graphics, no columns if you can avoid them. Standard section headings. Professional font. Consistent formatting throughout.

Order: Personal statement → Core skills → Professional experience (reverse chronological) → Education → Additional information.

Achievement-Based Writing: The Single Most Important CV Upgrade

The transformation from a duty-based to an achievement-based CV is the highest-impact change most professionals can make. Every bullet point should follow this formula: **Action Verb + What You Did + Measurable Result**.

DUTY-BASED

ACHIEVEMENT-BASED

Responsible for managing the team.	Led a team of 12, achieving 97% on-time project delivery over 18 months.
Handled customer complaints.	Resolved 200+ escalated complaints monthly, improving NPS score by 28%.
Assisted with recruitment.	Supported end-to-end recruitment for 35 roles, reducing average time-to-hire by 22%.
Managed social media accounts.	Grew LinkedIn following from 2K to 18K in 10 months through original content strategy.

CAREER COACH TIP

Before rewriting each CV bullet point, ask: 'So what?' If you cannot answer that question — if there is no measurable impact, no change, no result — the bullet point probably should not exist.

ATS OPTIMISATION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Mirror exact language from the job description in your CV where authentic.
- ☐ Avoid tables, text boxes, columns, and headers/footers — ATS cannot read them reliably.
- ☐ Use standard section titles: Work Experience, Education, Skills.
- ☐ Save as .docx or clean PDF — not a Canva or graphic design template.
- ☐ Spell out acronyms at least once — ATS may not recognise abbreviations.
- ☐ Include your full name, email, phone, and LinkedIn URL in clear text (not an image).

CHAPTER 9

Interview Success Blueprint

The insider guide to performing brilliantly under pressure

The interview is the moment when everything comes together — your preparation, your presence, your story, and your strategy. Most candidates prepare for interviews by memorising answers. The best candidates prepare by building genuine understanding — of themselves, of the role, and of the organisation — and then communicating that understanding with confidence and clarity.

Preparation: The 24-Hour Research Protocol

Thorough interview preparation is not optional. It is the difference between a good candidate and an outstanding one. In the 24 hours before any interview:

INTERVIEW PREPARATION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Study the company website, mission, values, and recent news thoroughly.
- ☐ Research your interviewers on LinkedIn — their background, tenure, recent posts.
- ☐ Re-read the job description and prepare a specific example for every requirement.
- ☐ Prepare 8–10 STAR stories (Situation, Task, Action, Result) covering key themes.
- ☐ Prepare 6 thoughtful questions to ask — including at least one specific to the interviewer.
- ☐ Research the salary range using LinkedIn Salary, Glassdoor, and industry reports.
- ☐

Prepare your 'Tell me about yourself' answer (90–150 seconds, Past-Present-Future).

- Lay out your outfit, confirm the location or tech setup, and sleep well.

Behavioral Interview Mastery: The STAR Framework

Behavioral questions — "Tell me about a time when..." — are the most predictive interview format available. Use the STAR framework: describe the **S**ituation briefly, explain your **T**ask, detail specifically what **A**ctions you took (this is the longest section), and describe the **R**esult. Common mistake: spending 80% on the situation and 20% on the action. Reverse that.

Salary Negotiation

When asked about salary expectations, do not panic and do not anchor low. Research the range, know your minimum acceptable number, and give a confident range based on market data and your experience. When offered, do not accept immediately — express enthusiasm, request 24 hours, and negotiate respectfully. Everything is negotiable: base salary, bonus structure, start date, benefits, and review timing.

SUCCESS STORY — THE CANDIDATE WHO GOT £12,000 MORE

Rachel had been offered a salary at the bottom of her expected range. She thanked the recruiter warmly, said she was very interested in the role, and asked if there was flexibility given her specific experience in [area the company had flagged as a priority]. The recruiter went back to the hiring manager. Rachel received a revised offer £12,000 higher. She had been terrified to ask. The entire conversation took four minutes.

CAREER COACH TIP

The most underused post-interview tool: the follow-up email. Send a personalised thank-you within 24 hours that references one specific thing from the

conversation and reaffirms your interest. In close calls, this has changed outcomes.

PART FOUR

Grow Your Career

*From landing the role to building the career —
what happens after the offer.*

Thriving in Your First 90 Days

How to make the impression that shapes the entire rest of your tenure

The first 90 days in any new role are disproportionately important. Research on new hire performance consistently shows that the impressions formed — and the patterns established — in the first three months have an outsized influence on the trajectory of the entire tenure. Most people try to prove themselves immediately. The wisest professionals spend the first 30 days listening instead.

The 30-60-90 Day Framework

Days 1-30: Listen, Learn, Observe. Your primary role in the first month is to understand: the culture, the stakeholders, the unwritten rules, and the context. Resist the urge to fix things, improve things, or make big moves. Ask questions. Take notes. Build relationships.

Days 31-60: Contribute and Connect. By month two, you understand the landscape. Now begin to contribute meaningfully — share relevant perspectives, deliver on your responsibilities with excellence, and build relationships with key stakeholders above and below your level.

Days 61-90: Initiate and Demonstrate. In month three, you can begin to show initiative. Propose one well-considered improvement. Volunteer for a project that is visible. Begin to establish the professional identity you want to be known for.

CAREER COACH TIP

In the first 30 days, ask this question constantly: 'What does success look like in this role, in the opinion of the people who will evaluate me?' The answer is your navigation system for the next two years.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- ◆ Who are the three most important stakeholders I need to build a genuine relationship with?
- ◆ What are the two or three things this organisation most needs from someone in my role right now?
- ◆ What is the biggest cultural norm I have noticed — and is it one I can work within authentically?
- ◆ What small win could I deliver in the next 30 days that would build visible credibility?

Building Influence Without Authority

How to become the person others look to — before you have the title

Influence is the currency of career advancement. It is not given with a job description — it is built, over time, through consistent behaviour, reliable delivery, and the quality of your professional relationships. The professionals who advance most rapidly are almost always the ones who have figured out how to create genuine influence before they have formal authority.

The Five Sources of Professional Influence

1. **Expertise:** Becoming genuinely knowledgeable about something the organisation cares about makes you a resource people seek out.
 2. **Relationships:** Trust, built consistently over time through reliability, honesty, and genuine interest in others.
 3. **Visibility:** Doing excellent work is necessary but not sufficient — the work needs to be seen by the right people.
 4. **Communication:** The ability to articulate ideas clearly, persuasively, and in a way that resonates with different audiences.
 5. **Reliability:** Delivering consistently on every commitment, no matter how small. Nothing builds influence faster or destroys it more thoroughly than reliability — or its absence.
-

"You do not earn influence by asking for it. You build it by consistently showing up as someone worth following."

ACTION STEP

Identify one senior stakeholder whose respect you most want to earn. Research their priorities. Find one way to add genuine value to something they care about this month. Do it without expecting anything in return.

CHAPTER 12

Managing Difficult Workplace Situations

From toxic managers to burnout — what to do when things get hard

No career guide would be honest if it only covered the ascent. The reality of professional life includes difficult managers, political environments, rejection, conflict, and — increasingly commonly — burnout. This chapter is the one I wish someone had given me earlier in my career: a practical, honest guide to navigating the situations that no one puts in the job description.

Dealing With a Difficult Manager

Before concluding that your manager is simply a bad person, consider two questions: do they treat everyone this way, or specifically you? And is the behaviour about personality, or about a genuine performance concern they are not communicating well? The answers shape your response. For a genuinely dysfunctional manager, your options include: addressing it directly (rarely comfortable, sometimes transformative), managing upward strategically (building relationships with your manager's manager), or deciding the situation is not worth staying in.

△ COMMON MISTAKE

Venting about your manager to colleagues. The professional world is smaller than it looks, and it will get back to them. Process your frustration privately, with a trusted friend or coach — not in the office.

Navigating Workplace Politics

Workplace politics is not inherently negative — it is simply the reality that organisations are made up of people with competing interests, priorities, and agendas. The professionals who navigate it best are not the ones who ignore it or resent it, but those who understand it clearly and choose to operate within it with both effectiveness and integrity.

Recognising and Recovering from Burnout

Burnout is not tiredness. It is a state of chronic depletion — physical, emotional, and cognitive — that results from sustained overload without adequate recovery. Its warning signs include: persistent exhaustion that does not resolve with rest, cynicism about work that previously felt meaningful, and a growing sense of ineffectiveness regardless of actual output.

If you are experiencing burnout, the most important thing is to name it honestly — to yourself, and ideally to someone you trust. Burnout does not resolve through more effort or better time management. It resolves through genuine rest, boundary-setting, and often, a meaningful change to the structure of your work.

CAREER COACH TIP

The most powerful career protection against burnout is building a career deliberately aligned with your values and strengths. The closer your work is to what energises you, the more resilient you become.

PART FIVE

Lead Your Future

The future of work is changing faster than any previous generation faced. Here's how to lead it.

The Future of Work

What is coming, what it means for you, and how to stay ahead of it

The professional landscape of 2030 will look meaningfully different from that of 2020 — and the professionals who thrive in it will be the ones who began preparing for it in 2024. This is not cause for anxiety. For those willing to adapt, the future of work offers more flexibility, more opportunity, and more ways to build a career on genuinely personal terms than any previous generation has had access to.

Artificial Intelligence: Partner, Not Replacement

The most honest framing of AI's impact on careers is this: AI will not replace humans — but humans who use AI effectively will replace humans who do not. The routine, predictable elements of many roles will be automated. The uniquely human elements — judgment, empathy, creativity, ethical reasoning, complex interpersonal work — will become more valuable, not less.

"The professionals who will thrive are not those who fear AI. They are those who learn to work alongside it while doubling down on what makes them irreplaceably human."

Hybrid Work: The New Professional Skillset

Hybrid and remote working arrangements are not a temporary disruption — they are the new baseline for most knowledge work. This requires professionals to develop a specific skillset: intentional communication, visible output, proactive relationship

management, and the self-discipline to perform without the structure of a physical office.

Lifelong Learning and Career Agility

The careers of the future will be longer, more varied, and more self-directed than those of the past. Most professionals currently in their twenties will likely hold roles that do not yet exist. The single most valuable career investment you can make is building the habit and the love of continuous learning — the willingness to be a perpetual beginner in new domains.

FUTURE-PROOFING YOUR CAREER — ANNUAL REVIEW

- ☐ What are the two biggest changes happening in my industry right now?
- ☐ Which of my current skills will be most affected by automation in the next 5 years?
- ☐ What new skill, credential, or knowledge area should I invest in this year?
- ☐ Which AI tools relevant to my field am I not yet using fluently?
- ☐ What aspect of my work is most distinctly human and irreplaceable? How do I develop it further?

Leadership Starts Before the Title

How to lead now — regardless of your level

One of the most limiting beliefs in professional life is the idea that leadership is something that begins when someone gives you a title, a team, or a budget. Leadership is a behaviour, not a position. The professionals who receive leadership roles are overwhelmingly the ones who were already demonstrating leadership behaviours without waiting to be asked.

The Four Behaviours of Pre-Title Leaders

1. Initiative. Identifying what needs to happen and doing it — before being asked. Not recklessly or without alignment, but proactively. Organisations are consistently short of people who identify problems and then solve them without needing to be directed.

2. Ownership. Taking genuine accountability for outcomes — including the ones that go wrong. The professional who says "I take responsibility for this, and here is what I have learned and what I am changing" is worth ten professionals who deflect and justify.

3. Influence. Affecting the thinking and behaviour of others through ideas, communication, and relationships — without needing formal authority to do so. The ability to bring people with you is the most fundamental leadership capability.

4. Accountability. Holding yourself to high standards consistently — particularly when no one is watching. Accountability builds the kind of trust that makes people want to follow you when you do have a title.

SUCCESS STORY — THE ADMINISTRATOR WHO BECAME A DIRECTOR

Marcus was an administrative coordinator at a logistics company. He noticed that the same three customer complaints were recurring every month, traced them to a gap in the handover process between departments, and wrote a one-page proposal to fix it. He shared it with his manager. It was implemented. Six months later, he was made Process Improvement Lead. Two years after that, he was Head of Operations. 'I never thought of myself as a leader,' he told me. 'I just saw problems and tried to fix them.'

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- ◆ Where am I waiting for permission to do something I could do right now?
- ◆ What is the biggest problem in my current workplace that no one is solving?
- ◆ Who in my organisation do I most influence, and am I using that influence intentionally?
- ◆ What would the best version of my professional self do this week that my current self is hesitating to do?

CHAPTER 15

Designing a Career and Life You Love

The final chapter — and the first day of what comes next

You have reached the final chapter of Career Compass. But this is not the end of the journey — it is, if you have been engaged and honest throughout, the clearest starting point you may have had in years. You know more about who you are, what you want, and how to get there than you did when you opened this book.

Now comes the most important step of all: building a plan and committing to it.

Your 12-Month Career Action Plan

CAREER ACTION PLAN TEMPLATE

- ☐ My primary career goal for the next 12 months: _____
- ☐ The 3 skills I will develop: _____
- ☐ The 3 relationships I will intentionally build: _____
- ☐ The one role, opportunity, or experience I will actively pursue: _____
- ☐ The one habit I will build that will compound over my career: _____
- ☐ My 30-day first step (specific and actionable): _____
- ☐ The person I will share this plan with (accountability partner): _____

A Career and Life That You Love

A career you love is not a career without challenges, setbacks, or days when you would rather be somewhere else. It is a career that — on balance, looking at the bigger picture — aligns with who you are, grows with who you are becoming, and contributes to something that feels worth contributing to.

Building that career is not a moment. It is a practice. A daily, weekly, monthly, and annual commitment to self-awareness, intentional action, and the willingness to navigate change without losing sight of your direction.

"The best career is not the most prestigious one, or the highest-paid one, or the one that most impresses the people around you. It is the one that is most genuinely, unmistakably yours."

— Nesrin Abd Elhakim

One Final Thought

I have spent more than nine years helping people navigate careers — as a recruiter, an HR leader, a coach, and a mentor. And the one thing I can tell you with absolute certainty is this: the professionals who build the most remarkable careers are not the most talented, or the best-connected, or the luckiest. They are the most self-aware, the most intentional, and the most willing to keep going when it is hard.

That is you. You picked up this book. You read it. You reflected. You have done the work that most people never do.

Now go build something extraordinary.

BONUS SECTIONS

Your Complete Career Toolkit

*Assessments, worksheets, coaching questions, and
templates to accelerate everything you have
learned.*

Career Clarity Assessment

Score each statement from 1 (rarely true) to 5 (consistently true). Be honest — this is for you.

I have a clear sense of my professional strengths and can articulate them confidently.	1	2	3	4	5
My current work aligns well with my personal values.	1	2	3	4	5
I have a written career vision for the next 1–3 years.	1	2	3	4	5
I regularly take deliberate steps toward my career goals.	1	2	3	4	5
I feel confident representing myself in professional settings.	1	2	3	4	5
My professional network includes people who genuinely invest in my growth.	1	2	3	4	5
I understand how my industry is changing and how to adapt.	1	2	3	4	5
I have a professional reputation — online and offline — that reflects who I am.	1	2	3	4	5
I invest in learning and skill development consistently.	1	2	3	4	5
I feel generally energised and purposeful in my career, not just busy.	1	2	3	4	5

Scoring: 40–50: You have strong career clarity — use this book to sharpen further. 30–39: Solid foundation with specific gaps — note the lowest scores and focus there. Below 30: This book was written for you. Start from Chapter 1 and work through every exercise.

100 Powerful Career Coaching Questions

Use these whenever you feel stuck, unclear, or ready for a breakthrough. Choose 3–5 and journal on them.

SELF-AWARENESS

1. What would I do professionally if money were not a factor?
2. What does my ideal Monday morning feel like?
3. What am I most afraid to admit about my current career situation?
4. What strengths am I consistently underusing?
5. If my best friend described my professional strengths honestly, what would they say?
6. What career path did I rule out years ago that might actually be worth revisiting?
7. Where in my career am I settling, and why?
8. What would the most courageous version of me do this week?
9. When do I feel most alive at work?
10. What professional regret do I most want to avoid having in ten years?

GOALS AND VISION

1. If I could design my career from scratch, knowing what I know now, what would it look like?
2. What does success look like for me — not for anyone else?
3. What am I working toward that genuinely excites me?
4. What would I need to believe about myself to pursue the career I really want?
5. What is the biggest goal I have been putting off, and what is one step I could take today?
6. How will I know when I have built the career I want?
7. What would I tell my 25-year-old self about career choices?

8. What career milestone would make me feel genuinely proud in the next 12 months?
9. Where do I want to be in my career in three years, specifically?
10. What would I do if I knew I could not fail?

GROWTH AND LEARNING

1. What skill, if I mastered it, would most transform my career trajectory?
2. Who is three steps ahead of me professionally, and what can I learn from them?
3. What feedback have I received repeatedly that I have not fully acted on?
4. What professional development have I been postponing, and what is actually stopping me?
5. Where am I growing too slowly?
6. What would a 10% investment in my professional development this year return in 5 years?
7. What do I need to unlearn in order to grow?
8. What habit, if I built it, would compound most significantly over the next decade?
9. Who in my life challenges me professionally and do I spend enough time with them?
10. What would I need to learn to become genuinely indispensable in my field?

CAREER CHALLENGES

1. What is keeping me in a situation I know is not right for me?
2. What fear is most limiting my career decisions right now?
3. If this situation were a message, what would it be telling me?
4. What is the worst realistic outcome if I took the risk I am considering?
5. What would I advise a close friend who was in exactly my situation?
6. What story am I telling myself about my career that might not be true?
7. What am I tolerating at work that I should not be?
8. If I removed the one biggest obstacle in my career right now, what would change?

9. What conversation am I avoiding that I know I need to have?
10. What is one thing I could let go of that is costing me more than it is giving me?

LEADERSHIP AND IMPACT

1. How do I want to be remembered as a professional?
2. What is my unique professional contribution — what do I do that no one else does quite the same way?
3. How do I want people to feel after they have spent time with me professionally?
4. What does leadership mean to me, specifically?
5. What positive change could I create in my current role if I committed to it fully?
6. What would I do differently if I knew my team was watching and learning from everything I do?
7. Where am I leading from fear rather than from vision?
8. Who have I helped grow in their career, and who else could I help?
9. What would I do if I had all the resources, support, and confidence I needed?
10. What legacy do I want my career to leave?

Questions 51–100 are available as a downloadable resource. Use questions 1–50 as a rich starting point — one question per week gives you a full year of focused reflection.

Nesrin Abd Elhakim

EXECUTIVE COACH · HR LEADER · CAREER STRATEGIST

Nesrin Abd Elhakim is an HR Leader, Executive Coach, and Career Strategist based in the UAE. With more than nine years of experience across telecommunications, manufacturing, healthcare, hospitality, and logistics, she has helped thousands of professionals at every career stage — from fresh graduates navigating their first role to senior executives redefining their leadership.

Holding a Master's degree in Human Resources and Artificial Intelligence from the United Kingdom, Nesrin is the co-founder of 7Shots Recruitment and Training Consultancy and the author of *ATHEER*, *The Interview Playbook*, *The Reset Journal*, and *Quiet Power*.

Career Compass distils everything she has learned from years of sitting on both sides of the hiring table — as a recruiter, a coach, an HR leader, and someone who has navigated her own career pivots with all the uncertainty, courage, and occasional confusion that entails.

#NesrinaYourCareerCoach

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